

Jung's Answer to Job

A Commentary



P A U L B I S H O P

Jung's *Answer to Job*

Greeted with controversy on its publication, *Answer to Job* has long been neglected by many serious commentators on Jung. This book offers an intellectual and cultural context for C.G. Jung's 1952 publication.

In *Jung's Answer to Job: A Commentary*, the author argues that such neglect is due to a failure to understand Jung's objectives in this text and offers a new way of reading the work. The book places *Answer to Job* in the context of biblical commentary, and then examines the circumstances surrounding its compositions and immediate reception. A detailed commentary on the work discusses the major methodological presuppositions informing it and explains how key Jungian concepts operate in the text. *Jung's Answer to Job: A Commentary* unravels Jung's narrative by reading it in the chronological order of the biblical events it analyses and the books to which it refers, offering a comprehensive re-reading of Jung's text. An original argument put across in a scholarly and accessible style provides an essential framework for understanding the work.

Whilst taking account of the tenets of analytical psychology, this commentary underlines *Answer to Job*'s more general significance in terms of cultural history. It will be invaluable to students and scholars of analytical psychology, the history of ideas, intercultural studies, comparative literature, religion and religious studies.

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In memoriam Anthony Storr (1920–2001)

Jung's *Answer to Job*

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Paul Bishop

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Our language is a faithful reflection of the psychic phenomenon with its dual aspect 'perceptual' and 'imaginary' . . . The language I use must be ambiguous, must have two meanings, in order to do justice to the dual aspect of our psychic nature.

Jung, letter to R.J. Zwi Werblowsky, 17 June 1952

A la différence de Job, je n'ai pas maudit le jour de ma naissance; les autres jours en revanche, je les ai tous couverts d'anathèmes . . .

Cioran, *De l'inconvénient d'être né* (1973)

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Abbreviations

AV	King James translation of the Bible (Authorized Version).
CW	C.G. Jung, <i>Collected Works</i> , ed. Sir Herbert Read, Michael Fordham, Gerhard Adler and William McGuire, 20 vols, London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1953–1983.
Freud/Jung	<i>The Freud/Jung Letters: The Correspondence between Sigmund Freud and C.G. Jung</i> , ed. William McGuire, tr. Ralph Manheim and R.F.C. Hull, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1979.
JB	Jerusalem Bible, general editor Alexander Jones, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1966.
L1	C.G. Jung, <i>Letters, 1906–1950</i> , ed. Aniela Jaffé and Gerhard Adler, tr. R.F.C. Hull, London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1973.
L2	C.G. Jung, <i>Letters, 1951–1961</i> , ed. Aniela Jaffé and Gerhard Adler, tr. R.F.C. Hull, London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1975.
MDR	C.G. Jung, <i>Memories, Dreams, Reflections</i> , recorded and edited by Aniela Jaffé, tr. Richard and Clara Winston, London: Collins/Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1963.
NT	New Testament
OT	Old Testament
PU	C.G. Jung, <i>Psychology of the Unconscious: A Study of the Transformations and Symbolisms of the Libido: A Contribution to the History of the Evolution of Thought</i> , tr. B.M. Hinkle (<i>Collected Works</i> , Supplementary Volume B), London: Routledge, 1991.
SE	Sigmund Freud, <i>The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud</i> , ed. James Strachey and Anna Freud, 24 vols, London: Hogarth Press, 1953–1974.

Note: Translations from German have been amended where necessary.

Introduction

One of the most remarkable aspects of the intellectual life of C.G. Jung (1875–1961) is the extraordinary diversity of interests he entertained throughout his long, and productive, career. Beginning with his activity as a psychiatrist in the Burghölzli Clinic in Zurich, which expanded into a university lecturing post and a successful private practice, Jung undertook empirical scientific experiments in word association, before coming under the influence of Freudian psychoanalysis. In the course of his professional association and personal friendship with Freud, he developed an interest in comparative mythology that is reflected in his first major work, *Wandlungen und Symbole der Libido* (*Transformations and Symbols of the Libido*, translated as *Psychology of the Unconscious*) (1911/12). This book also marked his break with Freud. In the early 1920s he completed a substantial work on psychological typology, but his interests were to move in the direction of other things: comparative religion, alchemy, astrology, and – notoriously – flying saucers. Nothing was too esoteric, or obscure, or even ridiculous, for Carl Jung. In the early 1940s, he collaborated with the Hungarian-born classical scholar Karl Kerényi (1897–1973) to produce a collection of papers, entitled *Essays on a Science of Mythology* (Swiss original, 1941; US translation, 1949), an examination of the myth of the divine child and the Mysteries of Eleusis. Then, in 1952, following a lengthy correspondence between the two,¹ he and the Austrian-born Swiss physicist Wolfgang Pauli (1900–58) published a volume entitled *The Interpretation of Nature and the Psyche* (Swiss original, 1952; US translation, 1955), which sought a rapprochement between subatomic physics and analytical psychology. He travelled widely, too, visiting the United States (1909; 1912; 1924–25; 1936; 1937), Great Britain (1919; 1925; 1935; 1938), Algeria and Tunisia (1920), the Pueblo Indians in New Mexico (1925), Kenya, Uganda, and the Nile, including a visit to the Elgonyi on Mount Elgon (1925–26), Egypt and Palestine (1933), and India (1938). Honorary degrees were awarded to him by Clark University (1909), Harvard University (1936), the universities of Calcutta, Benares, and Allahabad (1938), of Oxford (1938), Geneva (1945), and the Swiss Federal Polytechnic (ETH), Zurich (1955); and he was awarded the Literature Prize of the City of Zurich (1932), and appointed Titular Professor of the ETH, Zurich (1935), Honorary Fellow of the Royal Society of Medicine, London (1938), Honorary

Member of the Swiss Academy of Sciences (1943), to the Chair of Medical Psychology at the University of Basle (1943), and made an Honorary Citizen of Küsnacht (1960).

Not surprisingly, then, Jung had to appeal to a wide variety of audiences throughout his career. For example, on 4 July 1919 he addressed the Society for Psychical Research in London, whilst a few days later he was delivering a lecture to the Royal Society of Medicine in London, where he also gave a talk, twenty years later, in 1939. In 1927 he addressed Hermann Graf Keyserling's so-called School of Wisdom in Darmstadt; in 1929, the Literary Club of Zurich; and in 1934, the Kulturbund in Vienna. He gave a series of lectures to the Institute of Medical Psychology (the Tavistock Lectures) in 1935, to Yale University (the Terry Lectures) in 1938, and many of his most famous papers were first presented as lectures to the Eranos conferences. He gave radio interviews, wrote newspaper articles, and addressed medical colleagues and fellow analysts, as well as a wider public.

In 1952 the Rascher Verlag, which had been printing Jung's works for several decades, published a volume by the now world-famous psychologist entitled *Answer to Job*. The work proved controversial, and cost Jung his friendship with one of his closest intellectual companions, the Dominican priest and professor of dogmatic theology at Blackfriars in Oxford, Father Victor White (1902–60). Yet the work has received relatively little serious attention,² and the reason for this comparative neglect is not hard to find: the book is very hard to construe – and to make sense of it is even harder.

This neglect is a pity because, among Jung's mature works, *Answer to Job* stands out as presenting an argument that does not rely heavily on alchemical texts, and as representing an attempt on Jung's part to make a would-be valid public statement out of the solution to a psychological dilemma, at once personal and of wider significance. Furthermore, in tackling the Book of Job, Jung was situating himself in a distinguished line of eminent commentators on what is, by common consent, one of the most problematic texts of the Judeo-Christian Bible. If Jung is, as I have argued elsewhere,³ best appreciated within the intellectual traditions of German-speaking Europe, then we need to pay attention to his *Answer to Job*, which represents a significant, provocative, twentieth-century response to an ancient, foundational, fifth-century BCE text.

THE BOOK OF JOB AND ITS COMMENTATORS

Although it was probably written in the fifth century BCE, the Book of Job may in fact have been composed at any point between the seventh and the second centuries BCE. It, together with four other books (Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and two 'deuterocanonical' texts, Ecclesiasticus, and Wisdom),⁴ constitute the set of books known as the 'Wisdom' books.⁵ Equally 'inspired' literature, these works are nevertheless more reflective in tone and content than, say, the 'Law' books or the Prophets, and this is certainly true of the Book of Job. The editors of the Jerusalem Bible describe

it as ‘the literary masterpiece of the wisdom movement’ (JB, OT, p. 727). A figure from the patriarchal age of Noah and Daniel, Job served as a model of virtue for the prophet Ezekiel (Ezekiel 14:14, 20). From the story of his suffering, his patience in misfortune, and the eventual vindication of his faith, are derived such expressions as a ‘Job’s comforter’ and ‘Job’s post’. In *Henry IV: Part II*, Falstaff ironically refers to himself as being ‘as poor as Job, my lord, but not so patient’ (Act I, Scene ii).

The Book of Job opens with a prose narrative which begins: ‘There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was perfect and upright, and one that feared God, and eschewed evil’ (Job 1:1).⁶ Because of his virtue, Job enjoys prosperity and contentment, yet his fortunes change when Satan and Yahweh (the main Hebrew name for God) agree to the following wager:

Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the Lord, and Satan came also among them.

And the Lord said unto Satan, Whence comest thou? Then Satan answered the Lord, and said, From going to and fro in the earth, and from walking up and down in it.

And the Lord said unto Satan, Hast thou considered my servant Job, that there is none like him in the earth, a perfect and an upright man, one that feareth God, and escheweth evil?

Then Satan answered the Lord, and said, Doth Job fear God for nought?

Hast thou not made an hedge about him, and about his house, and about all that he hath on every side? thou hast blessed the work of his hands, and his substance is increased in the land.

But put forth thine hand now, and touch all that he hath, and he will curse thee to thy face.

And the Lord said unto Satan, Behold, all that he hath is in thy power; only upon himself put not forth thine hand. So Satan went forth from the presence of the Lord.

(Job 1:6–12, AV)

As a result, Job loses his oxen, his sheep, his camels, his servants, and his sons and daughters. But Job’s response is exemplary in the faith he retains in Yahweh: ‘Naked came I out of my mother’s womb, and naked shall I return thither: the Lord gave, and the Lord hath taken away; blessed be the name of the Lord’ (Job 1:21). Meeting with Yahweh again and discussing Job for a second time, Satan obtains permission to ‘touch his bone and his flesh’, provided he ‘save his life’; so Satan afflicts Job with ulcers and boils, and his wife urges him: ‘Curse God, and die.’ Yet Job persists in his faith in Yahweh: ‘What? shall we receive good at the hand of God, and shall we not receive evil?’ (Job 2:9–10).

The rest of the book falls into two sections: a set of speeches constituting an extended discussion between Job and his three friends, Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophār the Naamathite, later joined by Elihu, son of Barachel the Buzite ([chapters 3–37](#)), and a second set of speeches delivered from

Yahweh ‘out of the whirlwind’ (chapters 38–41). In his second speech, Yahweh acknowledges that he is, in the words of the commentary of the Jerusalem Bible, ‘master of the forces of evil’:

Then answered the Lord unto Job out of the whirlwind, and said,
Gird up thy loins now like a man: I will demand of thee, and declare
thou unto me.
Wilt thou also disannul my judgment? wilt thou condemn me, that thou
mayest be righteous?
Hast thou an arm like God? or canst thou thunder with a voice like him?
Deck thyself now with majesty and excellency; and array thyself with
glory and beauty.
Cast abroad the rage of thy wrath: and behold every one that is proud,
and abase him.
Look on every one that is proud, and bring him low; and tread down the
wicked in their place.
Hide them in the dust together; and bind their faces in secret.
Then will I also confess unto thee that thine own right hand can save thee.
(Job 40:6–14, AV)

In the conclusion to the book, Job retracts any accusations he made against Yahweh, and submits to the supremacy of God:

I know that thou canst do every thing, and that no thought can be withholden
from thee.
Who is he that hideth counsel without knowledge? therefore have I uttered
that I understood not; things too wonderful for me, which I knew not.
Hear, I beseech thee, and I will speak: I will demand of thee, and declare
thou unto me.
I have heard of thee by the hearing of the ear: but now mine eye seeth thee.
Wherefore I abhor myself, and repent in dust and ashes.
(Job 42:2–6, AV)

Whilst Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophār are rebuked by Yahweh and ordered to sacrifice seven bullocks and seven rams, Job’s fortunes are restored twofold, and he is given more sheep, camels, oxen, and asses, seven sons, and three daughters. ‘After this lived Job an hundred and forty years, and saw his sons, and his sons’ sons, even four generations. So Job died, being old and full of days’ (Job 42:16–17).

There is, of course, an extensive tradition of commentary on this text, as on other books of the Bible, to which the collection by Nahum Glatzer, *The Dimensions of Job* (1969), provides a helpful guide.⁷ (Glatzer excludes, however, Jung’s ‘weird analysis’ of Job (p. 45).) To give some idea of this tradition – of which Jung may well have been aware – one might mention that commentaries on the Book of Job were written by, among others, the Alexandrian theologian Didymus the Blind

(c.313–c.398), the Arian heretic Julian (c.357–c.380), Julian, the Pelagian Bishop of Eclanum (c.386–c.454), St John Chrysostom (c.347–407), and Pope Gregory I, the Great (c.540–604). The figure of Job is mentioned in the Qur'an, and presented as one of triumphant righteousness, although without reference to the circumstances related in the Hebrew Bible.⁸

Later commentaries include the sixteenth-century *Historia Jobs* of Johan Narhamer, the *Explication du livre de Job* (1732) of Jacques Joseph Duguet (1649–1733), and the translations into German (with commentary) by Wilhelm Carl Umbreit in 1824 and by Ferdinand Hitzig in 1874. Of the long and distinguished tradition of Jewish commentary on this text, Moses Maimonides, the twelfth-century philosopher and biblical and talmudic scholar, might serve as just one example. In chapters 22 and 23 of Part III of *The Guide for the Perplexed*, originally written in Arabic, Maimonides wrote that 'the strange and wonderful Book of Job' was 'a fiction, conceived for the purpose of explaining the different opinions which people hold on Divine Providence'. At the end of his commentary, Maimonides promised the reader: 'If you pay to my words the attention which this treatise demands, and examine all that is said in the Book of Job, all will be clear to you, and you will find that I have grasped and taken hold of the whole subject; nothing has been left unnoticed.'⁹ And indeed, of all the books of the Bible, Job has always been the one in which philosophers in the Western tradition have shown the greatest interest.

In eighteenth-century Germany,¹⁰ *On the Spirit of Hebrew Poetry* (1782–1783) by Johann Gottfried Herder (1744–1803) brought about a revolution in the approach to the Hebrew Bible, emphasizing its textual (i.e., literary) quality. A substantial section of this work quotes at length from the Book of Job, as Eutyphron tries to persuade Alciphron that, by 'secur[ing] that unity which the understanding demands' when contemplating the cosmos, Job, and Hebrew culture, was ahead of Lucretius (i.e., the Romans), as well as the Greeks and the Celts.¹¹ For Immanuel Kant (1724–1804), Herder's pupil and arguably Germany's most important Enlightenment thinker, the figure of Job was almost prototypical of the aims of the *Aufklärung*. 'On the Failure of All Philosophical Attempts at Theodicy' (1791), an essay attacking the outmoded world-view of Leibniz and Wolff, with all its scholastic presuppositions, presented the biblical figure in contrast to his friends in the following light:

Job speaks as he thinks, and with the courage with which he, as well as every human being in his position, can well afford; his friends, on the contrary, speak as if they were being secretly listened to by the Mighty One, over whose cause they are passing judgment, and as if gaining his favour through their judgment were closer to their heart than the truth. [. . .] If we now consider the theoretical position maintained by each side, that of Job's friends might convey more of an appearance of greater speculative reason and pious humility; before any court of dogmatic theologians, before a synod, an inquisition, a venerable congregation, or any higher consistory in our times (one alone excepted), Job would have likely suffered a sad fate.¹²

Just as Kant emphasized the radical honesty of Job, he drew attention to the ‘inscrutable’ nature of the deity that reveals itself in the Book of Job:

God deigned to lay before Job’s eyes the wisdom of his creation, especially its inscrutability. He allowed him glimpses into the beautiful side of creation, where ends comprehensible to the human being bring the wisdom and the benevolent providence of the author of the world unambiguously to light; but also, by contrast, into the horrible side, by calling out to him the products of his might, among which also harmful and fearsome things, each of which appears indeed to be purposively arranged for its own sake and that of its species, yet, with respect to other things and to human beings themselves, as destructive, counterpurposive, and incompatible with a universal plan established with goodness and wisdom. And yet God thereby demonstrates an order and a maintenance of the whole which proclaim a wise creator, even though his ways, inscrutable to us, must at the same time remain hidden – indeed already in the physical order of things, and how much more in the connection of the latter with the moral order (which is all the more impenetrable to our reason).¹³

Nor was Kant alone in the German philosophical tradition in taking particular interest in the figure of Job. Arguably his most important successor, Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770–1831), as a student ‘had a special delight in the Book of Job on account of its unconventionalized [*ungeregelter*] natural language’.¹⁴ Of course, Hegel was, like Herder, reading the text in the original Hebrew. Of less direct, but equal relevance, is the theology Hegel developed in his later years, as reflected in the section on ‘Revealed Religion’ in his *Encyclopedia* (1817, revised 1827 and 1830), a summary of his philosophy originally designed to accompany his lectures in Heidelberg. In the concluding paragraph of this section, Hegel wrote:

To grasp in thought, correctly and definitely, what God is as spirit, that requires thorough speculation. To begin with, this contains the following propositions: God is only God insofar as he knows himself; his knowing himself is, furthermore, a self-consciousness in man and man’s knowledge of God that goes on to man’s knowing himself *in* God.

*[Was Gott als Geist ist, dies richtig und bestimmt im Gedanken zu fassen, dazu wird gründliche Spekulation erfordert. Es sind zunächst die Sätze darin enthalten: Gott ist nur Gott, insofern er sich selber weiß; sein Sichwissen ist ferner sein Selbstbewußtsein im Menschen und das Wissen des Menschen von Gott, das fortgeht zum Sichwissen des Menschen in Gott.]*¹⁵

Hegel’s argument here anticipates the kind of complex dialectics in terms of which, in *Answer to Job*, Jung explored the way in which the consciousness of humankind and of God were caught up in a common process; and on 28 March 1953, in a letter

to Jakob Amstutz, he summarized his (Hegelian) argument in the following dramatic statement: ‘Man is the mirror which God holds up to himself, or the sense organ with which he apprehends his being’ (L2, p. 112).

In his lectures published as *On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History* (1841), the Scottish essayist and Germanophile Thomas Carlyle (1795–1881) lavished praise on the Book of Job, calling it ‘one of the grandest things ever written with pen’ and arguing that ‘there is nothing written [. . .] in the Bible or out of it, of equal literary merit’:

One feels, indeed, as if it were not Hebrew; such a noble universality, different from noble patriotism or sectarianism, reigns in it. A noble Book; all men’s Book! It is our first, oldest statement of the never-ending Problem, – man’s destiny, and God’s ways with him here in this earth. And all in such free flowing outlines; grand in its sincerity, in its simplicity; in its epic melody, and repose of reconciliation. There is the seeing eye, the mildly understanding heart. So *true* everywhere; true eyesight and vision for all things; material things no less than spiritual; the Horse, – ‘hast thou clothed his neck with *thunder*?’ – he ‘*laughs* at the shaking of the spear!’ Such living likenesses were never since drawn. Sublime sorrow, sublime reconciliation: oldest choral melody as of the heart of mankind; – so soft, and great; as the summer midnight, as the world with its seas and stars!¹⁶

In *Repetition* (1843), the Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard (1813–55), now widely regarded as the founding father of Existentialism – and one of Hegel’s most vociferous intellectual opponents – discussed Job’s destitution and subsequent compensation. And in one of his four *Edifying Discourses* (1843) he presented a commentary on the verse ‘The Lord gave, and the Lord hath taken away’ (Job 1:21), writing: ‘Only the thoughtless man could wish that Job should not accompany him, that his venerable name should not remind him of what he seeks to forget – that terror and anxiety exist in life.’¹⁷ Yet the issues raised by the Book of Job run right through Kierkegaard’s writings, such as *Fear and Trembling* (1843). Even though the episode that forms the focus of this work is the story of how Abraham was commanded to sacrifice his son Isaac, it touches on the same question of the relation between faith and reason, and the implications for how we choose to act. Corresponding in 1954 with Père William Lachat and in 1957 with the Reverend David Cox, Jung chose yet another biblical example to make a similar point, the story of how the prophet Hosea was commanded to marry a whore, thereby ‘making himself ridiculous’ and ‘overturning the traditional order’:¹⁸

[T]he action of the Holy Spirit does not meet us in the atmosphere of a normal, bourgeois (or proletarian!), sheltered, regular life, but only in the insecurity outside the human economy, in the infinite spaces where one is alone with the *providentia Dei*. We must never forget that Christ was an innovator and revolutionary, *executed with criminals*. The reformers and great religious

geniuses were *heretics*. It is there that you find the footprints of the Holy Spirit, and no one asks for him or receives him *without having to pay a high price*. The price is so high that no one today would dare to suggest that he possesses or is possessed by the Holy Spirit, or he would be too close to the psychiatric clinic. The danger of making oneself ridiculous is too real, not to mention the risk of offending our real god: *respectability*. [. . .] And yet how can there be religion without the experience of the divine will? Things are comparatively easy as long as God wants nothing but the fulfilment of his laws, but what if he wants you to break them, as he may do equally well? Poor Hosea could believe in the symbolic nature of his awkward marriage, but what about the equally poor little doctor who has to swear his soul away to save a human life? (CW 18 §1539 and §1637)

(Kierkegaard's reading of Job formed the basis of a discussion of the biblical text by the French existentialist philosopher Jean Wahl (1888–1974), who, like Jung, placed great emphasis on the rightness of Job's position vis-à-vis God.¹⁹ And another later biblical commentator has seen the Book of Job as a work which, in Kierkegaard's phrase from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), 'keeps the wound of the negative open'.²⁰)

In a widely read and influential work from the end of the nineteenth century, William Hale White (1831–1913), who wrote under the pseudonym 'Mark Rutherford', referred to the Book of Job as part of his classic exposition of the shift from religious dissent to doubt. In *Mark Rutherford's Deliverance* (1885), the sequel to *The Autobiography of Mark Rutherford, Dissenting Minister* (1881), the story of Job was used to illustrate the position that it would be 'a mockery to think about love for the only God whom I knew, the forces that maintained the universe':

In Job, God reminds us that man is not the measure of his creation. The world is immense, constructed on no plan or theory which the intellect of man can grasp. It is *transcendent* everywhere. This is the burden of every verse, and is the secret, if there be one, of the poem. Sufficient or insufficient, there is nothing more [. . .] God is great, we know not his ways. He takes from us all we have, but yet if we possess our souls in patience, we *may* pass the valley of the shadow, and come out in sunlight again. We may or we may not! [. . .] What more have we to say now than God said from the whirlwind over a thousand five hundred years ago?²¹

Jung may well have known this passage, for it is quoted in William James's *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature* (1902), first delivered as the Gifford Lectures on Natural Religion at Edinburgh in 1901/02. As James himself wrote to a friend, these lectures were highly popular,²² and Jung alluded to the discussion of Job in the eighteenth lecture in his letter to his friend, the pastor and theologian Adolf Keller (1872–1963), of September 1956 (L2, p. 330). In that chapter, entitled 'Philosophy', James had attacked dogmatic theology (otherwise

known as systematic theology, the exposition of Christian doctrine) and, in particular, its arguments for the existence of a holy, omnipotent, omniscient, just, loving, and unalterable God, declaring of such arguments:

It stands with them as ill as with the arguments for [God's] existence. Not only do post-Kantian idealists reject them root and branch, but it is a plain historic fact that they never have converted any one who has found in the moral complexion of the world, as he experienced it, reasons for doubting that a good God can have framed it. To prove God's goodness by the scholastic argument that there is no non-being in his essence would sound to such a witness simply silly.

No! the book of Job went over this whole matter once for all and definitively. Ratiocination is a relatively superficial and unreal path to the deity: 'I will lay mine hand upon my mouth; I have heard of Thee by the hearing of the ear, but now mine eye seeth Thee.' An intellect perplexed and baffled, yet a trustful sense of presence – such is the situation of the man who is sincere with himself and with the facts, but who remains religious still.²³

Among James's conclusions about the religious person's experience in the final chapter of his work were the propositions that 'the visible world is part of a more spiritual universe from which it draws its chief significance', that 'union or harmonious relation with that higher universe is our true end', and that 'spiritual energy flows in and produces effects, psychological or material, within the phenomenal world'.²⁴ Such views reflect the Swedenborgian beliefs of William's father, Henry James senior, and would have chimed well with the attitude toward religion adopted by Jung, who himself was at least familiar with some of the teachings of Swedenborg.²⁵

Throughout the twentieth century, the figure of Job has remained a compelling one for all kinds of thinkers and intellectuals, in both the German-speaking and English-speaking worlds.²⁶ For example, in 1917 the Austrian Expressionist Oskar Kokoschka (1886–1980) turned a short play into a three-act drama called *Hiob*, and the biblical story into an allegory of sexuality, producing the play in Dresden and publishing the text with 14 lithographs. In 1919 the novelist H.G. Wells (1866–1946) (whom Jung met on a couple of occasions) published *The Undying Fire*, subtitled *A Contemporary Novel*, which re-enacts the biblical legend in the form of conversations among the ruined and now cancer-ridden ex-headmaster of Woldingstanton School, Mr Job Huss (= Job of Uz), with the governors, Dr Elihu Barrack (= Elihu son of Barachel), Sir Eliphaz Burrows (= Eliphaz), Mr William Dad (= Bildad) and Mr Joseph Farr (= Zophār), who wish to turn the school into a modern commercial school (the 'undying fire' in Man of the title is the refusal to 'curse God and die').²⁷ The Jewish philosopher Lev Shestov (1866–1938) wrote a study called *In Job's Balances* (1929), which included essays on Tolstoy, Dostoevsky, Spinoza, Pascal, and Plotinus, and in 1930 the German novelist Joseph Roth (1894–1939) published *Hiob, Roman eines einfachen Mannes*, the story of

Mendel Singer (the Job of Roth's title) and his family, Jews who emigrate from Russian Galicia to America.

The years following the Second World War showed an increase in the number of adaptations of the Job story, sometimes (but not always) with reference to its Jewish context. In 1945 the American poet Robert Frost (1874–1963) published the first of his two dramatic poems on theological themes, *A Masque of Reason*, in which God speaks the ironic words to Job:

You realize by now the part you played
To stultify the Deuteronomist
And change the tenor of religious thought.
My thanks are to you for releasing me
From moral bondage to the human race

and Job is moved to remark:

The chances are when there's so much pretence
Of metaphysical profundity
The obscurity's a fraud to cover nothing.
I've come to think no so-called hidden value's
Worth going after. Get down into things
It will be found there's no more given there
Than on the surface. If there ever was,
The crypt was long since rifled by the Greeks.²⁸

In 1946 the critic and philosopher Margarete Susmann (1872–1966), who lived in Zurich, wrote a work entitled *Das Buch Hiob und das Schicksal des jüdischen Volkes* (1946), which investigated the identity of Job and the people of Israel, represented in Isaiah 53 by the figure of the suffering servant. Written in 1947–48, the drama *Der Blinde* (*The Blind Man*) by the Swiss playwright Friedrich Dürrenmatt (1921–90) reset the story of Job at the time of the Thirty Years War, deriving its dramatic tension from the conflict between the blind Duke (= Job) and the Italian nobleman, Negro da Ponte (= Satan). Martin Buber wrote in *The Prophetic Faith* (1949) that, 'in order to grasp the great inner dialectic of the poem', the reader must understand that the book presents 'four views of God's relationship to man's sufferings': that of the Prologue, that of the friends, that of Job 'in his complaint and protest', and that of God Himself. 'In spite of its thorough rhetoric – the product of a long drawn-out literary process', Job is, Buber recognized, 'one of the special events in world literature, in which we witness the first clothing of a human quest in form of speech'.²⁹ The year 1950 saw the publication of *Job or the Four Mirrors* by Karl Wolfskehl (1869–1948), a series of declamatory poems which foregrounded the relationship of Job to four other biblical figures: the people of Israel, Samson, the Prophet, and the Messiah.³⁰ Indeed, Wolfskehl himself had earlier identified himself with Job, when he wrote in 1933:

From that day on, when the ship left the harbour of Europe, I have known, lived, spoken, sobbed, and sung of the sign under which my life, the last phase of this earthly existence, has since stood. This sign, which is more than just an image, is the eternal calling of the Jewish fate. And I, flinchingly and almost reluctantly obedient, feel that, as the co-administrator, the co-protector of the German spirit, I am destined to represent the living, indeed, the creative symbol of this fate. From that moment on, everything I am, everything I create, has stood under the eternal name of Job; since then I have been, lived, experienced Job. Everything which, since then, I have written carries this name or, even when it appears to be have arisen independently, is pervaded by it.³¹

Beginning in the 1960s and 1970s, the emphasis of biblical criticism on the *literary* quality of the text drew attention to the ironic³² and the poetic³³ qualities of Job. (The hit Broadway playwright Neil Simon offered a comic re-imagining of the Job story in *God's Favorite* (1974), in which Joe Benjamin promises never to renounce God, come hell or high water... and promptly gets the modern equivalent.³⁴) Then, in 1982, the literary critic Northrop Frye (whose earlier book *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) had been influenced by Jungian ideas) published *The Great Code*, a study of the Bible – albeit not ‘a work of Biblical scholarship’, but rather an expression of Frye’s own ‘personal encounter with the Bible’.³⁵ Like Jung in his *Answer to Job*, Frye saw the Bible in terms of ‘a unified structure of narrative and imagery’ (p. xiii), and he compared the biblical narrative to a sequence of human life:

If we follow the narrative of the Bible as a sequence of events in human life, it becomes a series of ups and downs in which God’s people periodically fall into bondage and are then rescued by a leader, while the great heathen empires rise and fall in the opposite rhythm. At a certain point this perspective goes into reverse, and what we see is something more like an epic or romantic hero descending to a lower world to rescue what is at the same time a single bride and a large host of men and women. In this perspective the *sequence* of captivities and redemptions disappears and is replaced by a unique act of descent and return. But the act, if in itself unique, has many symbolic settings. (pp. 192–93)

Frye claimed that the Book of Job, ‘though it is classed with wisdom literature and includes a eulogy of wisdom, cannot be understood by the canons of wisdom alone’, but ‘needs the prophetic perspective to understand it’ (pp. 129, 198). In the Book of Job, Frye detects what he calls ‘the narrative unit in the Bible’, a U-shaped curve – ‘the U-shaped progression of original prosperity, descent to humiliation, and return’: ‘Job, like Adam, falls into a world of suffering and exile, “repents” (i.e., goes through a *metanoia* or metamorphosis of consciousness), and is restored to his original state, with interest’ (pp. 128, 198, 193). As such, the Book of Job is ‘the epitome of the narrative of the Bible’ as a whole (p. 193), and although it is ‘usually classified among the tragedies’, it is, Frye contended, ‘technically a

comedy of virtue of its “happy ending”, with Job restored to prosperity’ – albeit with, Frye suggested, the hint of a possible twist at the end:

The sequence of resolutions at the end follows the usual Biblical pattern. First is the restoration of the human community: we are told that God turned the captivity of Job when he prayed for his friends (42:10), even though what the friends have said ‘in God’s behalf’, to use Elihu’s phrase, is not acceptable. The reintegration of the human community is followed by the transfiguration of nature, in its humanized pastoral form. One of Job’s beautiful new daughters [‘Keren-happuch’, AV; ‘Mascara’, JB; Job 42:14] has a name meaning a box of eye shadow. Perhaps if we were to see Job in his restored state we should see, not beautiful daughters or sixteen thousand sheep, but only a man who has seen something that we have not seen, and knows something that we do not know.

(p. 197)

As well as in literature and philosophy, the story of Job has been a major theme for painters and musicians.

Perhaps the most famous examples in the visual arts are the two major cycles of illustrations by William Blake (1757–1827), a series of watercolours produced largely in 1805 to 1806, and a second set of engravings produced in 1823 to 1826, which show Blake at his most striking. (Even though Jung described himself as ‘no particular friend of Blake’, and regarded Blake’s work as ‘an artistic production rather than an authentic representation of unconscious processes’, the engravings have found at least one commentator from the school of Jung.³⁶) In Jung’s lifetime, two British composers wrote pieces based on the story about Job: in 1892, Hubert H. Parry (1848–1918) composed an oratorio for voices and orchestra, entitled *Job*, and in 1935 Ralph Vaughan Williams (1872–1958) wrote *Job: A Masque for Dancing*. The British composer Peter Maxwell Davies has also composed a piece for four soloists, chorus and orchestra called *Job* (1997), based on Stephen Mitchell’s translation (1979) of the biblical work.

At the beginning of the 1980s, the literary theorist Hans-Robert Jauss (born 1921), drawing on the earlier discussions of the Book of Job by Hans Blumenberg (1920–96) and Ernst Bloch (1885–1977), drew a line of continuity between the biblical text, Goethe’s *Faust*, Nietzsche’s parable of the madman in *The Gay Science*, and Heidegger’s discussion of that text in a 1943 lecture.³⁷ At around the same time, the American psychiatrist Israel J. Gerber used the Book of Job as a focus for his investigation into the religious aspects of suffering in *Job on Trial: A Book for Our Time* (1982). In Dame Muriel Spark’s novel *The Only Problem* (1984), the only problem – that of suffering – forms the backdrop to the story of Harvey, a former theological student whose tranquil life, spent writing a monograph on the Book of Job and admiring Georges de la Tour’s painting *Job visité par sa femme*, is disturbed by the arrest of his former wife on terrorist charges. In 1985, René Girard offered a reading of the text in terms of the theory of ‘mimetic desire’,

according to which ‘the unanimous violence of the group is transfigured into a sacred epiphany’.³⁸ Once freed from the Prologue, he argued, the dialogues of the Book of Job ‘present something particularly conclusive and convincing about the principles that govern the transformation of collective violence into the sacred’, demonstrating ‘the *all against one* of the scapegoat mechanism’ (pp. 31, 24). Contrasting Oedipus, ‘a *successful* scapegoat, because he is never recognized as such’, with Job, ‘a *failed* scapegoat’, Girard claimed that Job ‘derails the mythology that is meant to envelop him, by maintaining his own point of view in the face of the formidable unanimity surrounding him’ and that, ‘[b]y remaining faithful to the truth revealed by the victim, Job is the true hero of knowledge rather than Oedipus, who is perceived as such in the philosophical tradition’ (p. 35). Among the theologians proper, in *The Betrayal of God: Ideological Conflict in Job* (1990), the biblical scholar David Penchansky uses Western Marxist, French Structuralist, Russian Formalist, and deconstructive techniques of interpretation to offer a ‘dissonant reading’ of Job,³⁹ and to investigate those ‘rough, violent, unpredictable’ qualities of the God described in the Hebrew Bible, particularly the Book of Job, which suggest that ‘the portrait of the deity’ in this book was ‘ironical and deliberately deconstructive’.⁴⁰

In the early 1990s, as if to show its perennial importance, as well as the variety of readings that it can sustain, the *New York Times* columnist William Safire interpreted the Book of Job as an example of political expression in which Job emerged as ‘the first dissident’, showing how the biblical text offers ‘the blueprint for modern dissidence’, and arguing that ‘in the exercise of any kind of power, the best way to create a constituency of the devout is to stimulate the creativity of the defiant’.⁴¹ And in 1995, the columnist and former Jesuit Jack Miles offered a reading not just of the Book of Job but of the entire Hebrew Bible that is remarkably close to Jung’s analysis (without, however, apparently drawing on Jung). In *God: A Biography*, Miles showed how one could read the Bible as ‘God’s story’, treating God as a ‘literary character’, ‘the protagonist of a classic of world literature’. For Miles, ‘when we read the Bible as a work of literature in which God is the protagonist, it becomes the story of how he gradually became both more unitary and more ethical’ – the story, no less, of ‘God’s self-discovery’.⁴² Attempting, as Jung did, ‘a consciously postcritical or postmodern reintegration of mythic, fictional, and historical elements in the Bible so as to allow the character of God to stand forth more clearly from the work of which he is the protagonist’, Miles argues that ‘Job becomes the starting point in the life of God, reading that life as a movement from self-ignorance to self-knowledge’. Miles rejects traditional interpretations of Job’s final reply in chapter 42 in terms of repentance, seeing it instead as ‘irony responding to sarcasm’ – the sarcasm, that is, of the Lord’s speeches from the whirlwind. In those speeches, Miles writes, ‘the Lord’s inscrutable ways have been made all too scrutable’, and the encounter with Job has changed both God and humankind:

[Job] harangues God, countercharacterizing him relentlessly as not the kind of God who would do what we the readers know he has just done. Without